



NICCOLO PAGANINI

An anonymous portrait shows Paganini gaunt and with furrowed brow, wearing his trademark black suit. Chronic illness, for which he took lethal doses of mercury and opium, plagued much of his life. The composer was said to be a gambler (a habit learned from his father), on at least one occasion pawning his violin to pay off his debts; he was also an inveterate womanizer who, according to rumor, had been imprisoned for murdering one of his conquests.